

Getting your laptop ready

Quantitative Methods in Neuroscience, Master in Neuroscience, University of Geneva, 2026-27

The practicals in this course are Python notebooks that you run on your own laptop. This guide takes you from a blank machine to a working setup. Please do it **before the first practical**, so that we can spend that session on the material rather than on installations.

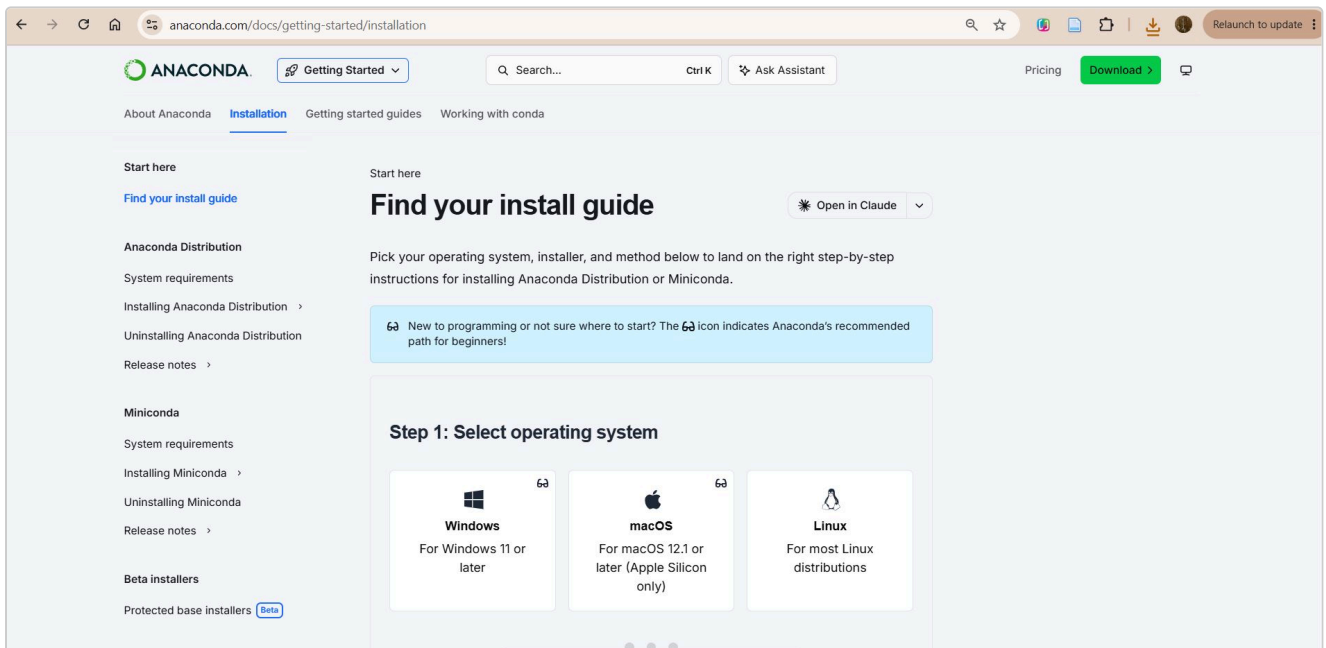
It takes about half an hour, most of which is waiting for downloads, and you only ever do it once. You need an internet connection and about 5 GB of free disk space: the environment itself takes a little over 2 GB, and the installers and conda's download cache need room while they work. No previous experience with Python or with a terminal is assumed.

What you will end up with: conda (a tool that manages Python and its libraries), Visual Studio Code (the editor we will write and run the notebooks in), and an environment called `qmn` that contains every library the course needs.

Step 1. Install conda

Go to the Anaconda installation page and pick, in order, your operating system, then **Miniconda**, then the **graphical installer**:

<https://www.anaconda.com/docs/getting-started/miniconda/install>



The page opens on "Find your install guide". Start with Step 1 and choose your system.

Step 1: Select operating system


Windows
For Windows 11 or later


macOS
For macOS 12.1 or later (Apple Silicon only)


Linux
For most Linux distributions

Step 2: Select distribution installer

For help deciding, see [Choosing between Anaconda Distribution and Miniconda](#).

Anaconda Distribution
Contains the conda package manager and 600+ packages

Miniconda
Contains only conda, Python, and their dependencies

Step 3: Select installer file type

Graphical installer
Easy-to-use installer with visual interface

CLI installer
Command-line installer for advanced users

Choose **Miniconda** in Step 2 and the **graphical installer** in Step 3, then follow the instructions the page gives you for your system.

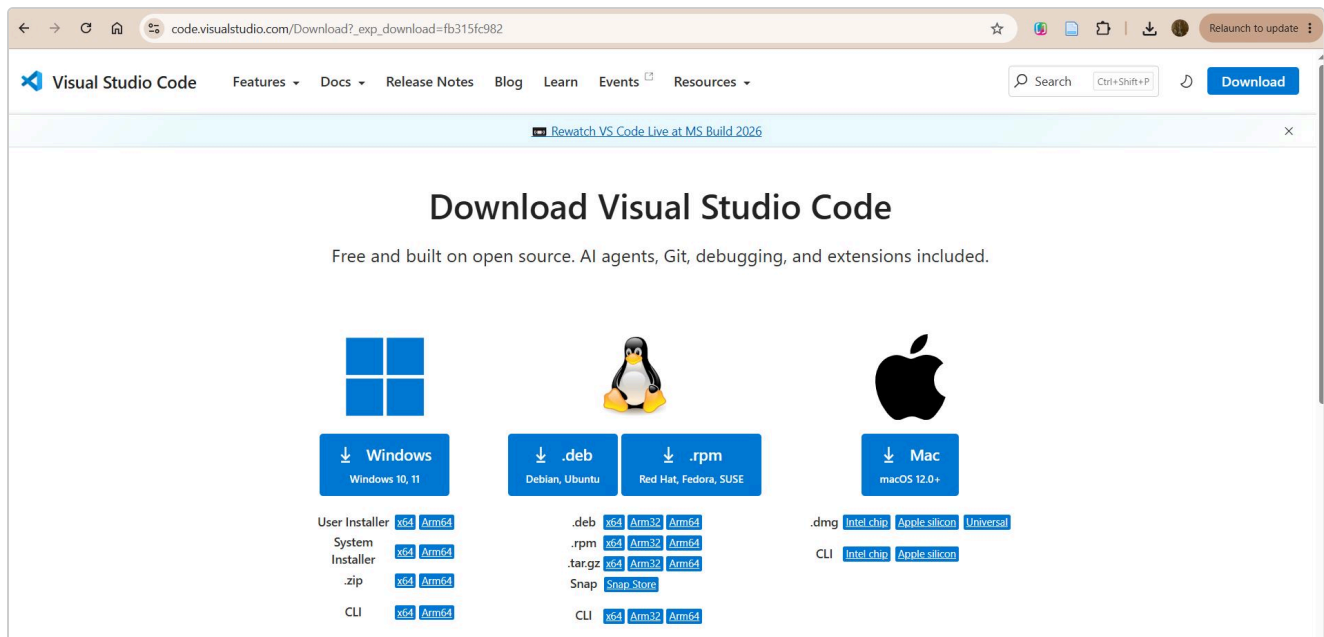
Run the installer and proceed with the options it recommends. On Windows, leave the PATH option as the installer sets it.

Already have Anaconda? Then you already have conda and can skip this step. Anaconda and Miniconda are the same tool; Miniconda simply installs fewer things you will not use.

Step 2. Install Visual Studio Code

Download it for your system and install it with the default options:

```
https://code.visualstudio.com/Download
```



Pick the button for your operating system. On a Mac, choose the version matching your chip if you are asked, Apple silicon or Intel.

Then open VS Code, click the **Extensions** icon in the left bar, and install these two official Microsoft extensions, searching for them by name:

- **Python**, which also brings Pylance and the Python debugger
- **Jupyter**, which lets you run notebooks inside VS Code

Step 3. Make the course folder

Create a folder called **QMN_course** directly inside your user folder, the one named after you:

```
Windows      %USERPROFILE%\QMN_course
macOS, Linux ~/QMN_course
```

%USERPROFILE% and ~ are shorthand for that folder, so you never have to type your user name. Another place works too, inside Documents for instance, as long as you use your own path in the commands of Step 4.

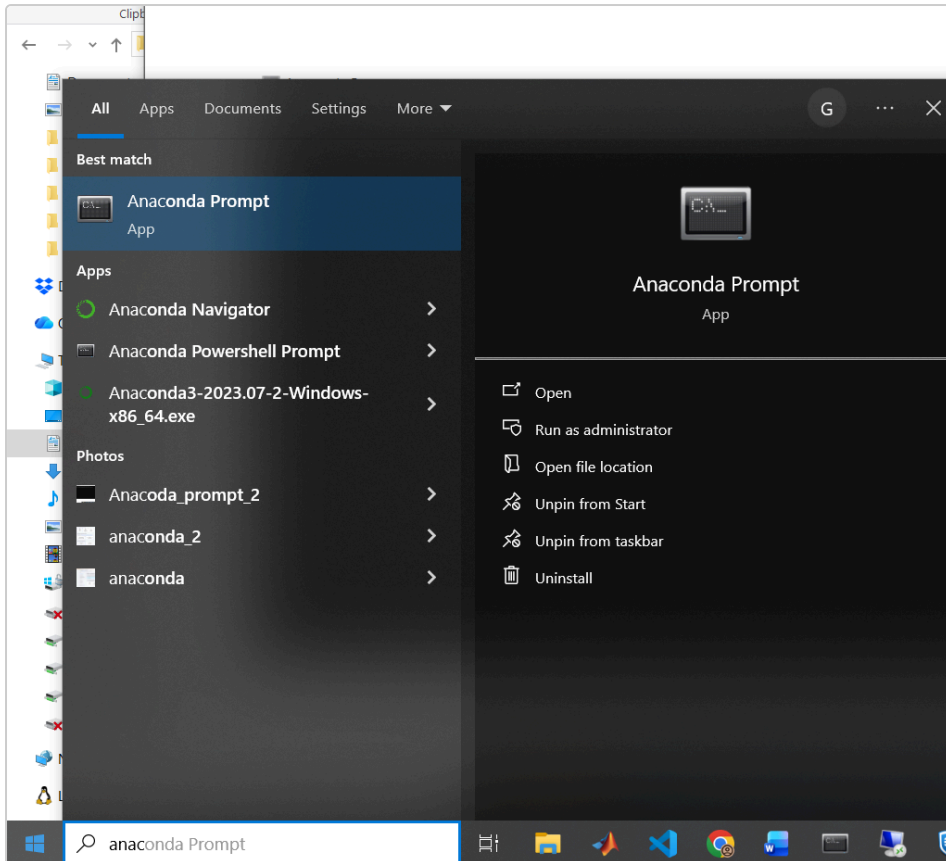
Save the file **environment.yml**, attached to the same message as this guide, inside that folder. It is a short text file listing the libraries the course uses. The course notebooks and data will be published on Moodle before the first practical, and they go in the same folder.

Check the name of the file. It has to be exactly `environment.yml`. Windows hides file extensions by default, so a file that looks right in the folder can in fact be `environment.yml.txt`, and a second download usually arrives as `environment (1).yml`. In File Explorer turn on **View**, then **Show**, then **File name extensions** to see the real name, and rename the file if it needs it.

Step 4. Create the qmn environment

Open a terminal in which conda is available:

- **Windows:** press the Windows key, type `anaconda prompt`, and open the **Anaconda Prompt** app
- **macOS or Linux:** open the Terminal application



On Windows, look for "Anaconda Prompt" in the start menu rather than using the normal command prompt.

Check that conda is there. Type this and press Enter:

```
conda --version
```

You should see something like `conda 24.9.0`. If instead you get "command not found", close the window, open it again, and try once more.

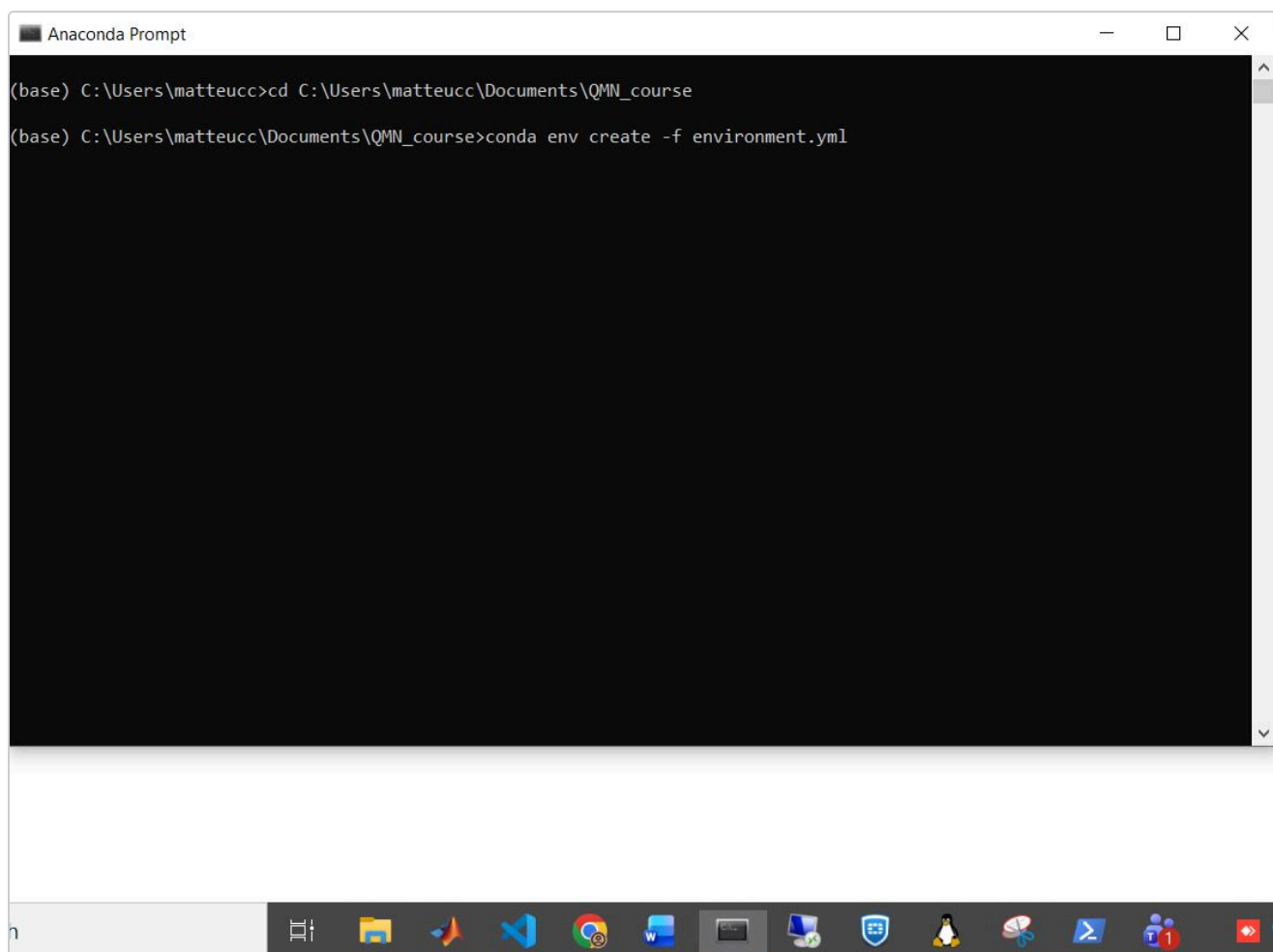
Now move into the folder you made in Step 3 and list what is inside it:

```
cd %USERPROFILE%\QMN_course
dir
```

On macOS and Linux these two are `cd ~/QMN_course` and `ls`. You should see **environment.yml** in the list. If you do not, you are in a different folder or the file is not named the way you think, and it is worth sorting that out before going further.

Then create the environment. This command reads `environment.yml` and installs everything it lists:

```
conda env create -f environment.yml
```

A screenshot of an Anaconda Prompt window. The title bar says "Anaconda Prompt". The terminal shows two commands: `(base) C:\Users\matteucc>cd C:\Users\matteucc\Documents\QMN_course` and `(base) C:\Users\matteucc\Documents\QMN_course>conda env create -f environment.yml`. The terminal is mostly black with white text. The Windows taskbar is visible at the bottom with various icons like File Explorer, VS Code, Chrome, Word, and others.

```
(base) C:\Users\matteucc>cd C:\Users\matteucc\Documents\QMN_course
(base) C:\Users\matteucc\Documents\QMN_course>conda env create -f environment.yml
```

Changing folder, then creating the environment. On this machine the course folder sits inside Documents, which is why the path is longer than the one above.

This downloads and installs Python and every library the course needs, so it takes roughly 5 to 15 minutes depending on your connection. It is normal for it to look stuck for a while on "Solving environment". When it finishes, activate the environment:

```
conda activate qmn
```

Your prompt should now start with (qmn).

If conda tells you that qmn already exists, you are doing this a second time, on a machine where the environment was already set up once. Do not delete it and do not run the create command again. Bring the one you have up to date instead, from the same folder:

```
conda env update -n qmn -f environment.yml --prune
```

Step 5. Check that it worked

With (qmn) showing in the prompt, type this one line and press Enter:

```
python -c "import numpy, pandas, matplotlib, scipy; print('all good')"
```

If it prints **all good**, your environment is ready and you are done. If it prints an error instead, see the next section.

One last thing you can try, if you like. Open VS Code, use File then Open Folder to open your QMN_course folder, and check that VS Code offers qmn when a notebook asks you to select a kernel. We will do this together in the first practical, so it is fine to stop here.

If something goes wrong

Installation problems are normal and are usually specific to one machine. Two things help:

Ask an AI assistant, giving it this guide

Tools such as ChatGPT or Claude are genuinely good at this, and they help much more when they can see what you are following. Upload this PDF into the chat first, then copy the exact error message from the terminal, say which step you were on and which operating system you are using. For example: "Here is the setup guide I am following. I am on Windows 11, and at the step `conda env create -f environment.yml` I get this error, what should I do?" Then follow the suggestions one at a time, and check the result after each one before trying the next.

Write to us

If you are still stuck after twenty minutes, do not lose an evening over it. Send us an email at **giulio.matteucci@unige.ch** or **sami.el-boustani@unige.ch**, with your operating system, the step you reached, and a screenshot of the error, and we will sort it out with you. You can also come to the first practical with it unfinished: bring your laptop and we will fix it there.

Coming back to it later

You never repeat Step 4. Each time you work on the course, open the Anaconda Prompt or Terminal and run:

```
cd %USERPROFILE%\QMN_course
conda activate qmn
code .
```

The last line opens the course folder in VS Code.

One thing will happen during the semester: we may post an updated `environment.yml` when a later week needs a package that is not in it yet. Put the new file in the course folder, in place of the old one, and run this from there:

```
conda activate qmn
conda env update -n qmn -f environment.yml --prune
```

That brings the environment you already have up to date. You never create it a second time.